

THREE PARTS, WRITE YOURS TONIGHT

The pitch that got me in with no PM experience

The hardest part of moving into product is not the interview. It is the moment before the interview, when someone asks what you do and you have to explain why a person with your background should be given a job you have never held.

Most people answer that badly, and I did too for a long time. The bad answer is a list of what you have done, delivered apologetically, with the gap in the middle where the PM experience should be.

The answer that worked for me was not about experience at all. It was three sentences about what I am. I used it on a Microsoft CVP at a conference with no case studies, no portfolio and no plan, and it produced a referral to a recruiter inside a single conversation.

Here is the structure, why each part exists, and how to write yours.

1 Part one, the hardest thing you actually own

Open with the most technically specific thing you do, described plainly enough that someone outside your field understands why it is hard.

Mine was this. I work on the platform controller hub. That is how everything on a chip, SATA, eMMC, SD card, connects back to the CPU. We are what lets the CPU do anything at all, because on its own the CPU is just a calculator that runs very fast.

Notice that it is specific and it is explained. Specificity without explanation is jargon, and jargon makes the listener feel stupid, which is not a feeling you want attached to you.

EXAMPLE

Write one sentence naming the hardest real thing you work on, then one sentence explaining why it matters, in words your parents would follow. If you cannot explain it simply you do not understand it well enough to lead with it.

WHY THIS MATTERS: this part buys you the right to be taken seriously. Everything after it is heard differently because of it.

2 Part two, the unpaid proof of the other half

Now show the thing you do that nobody pays you for.

Mine was this. On weekends I build Alexa skills in Java, and some of them are live and people use them.

This is the load-bearing sentence and it is the one people leave out. Anyone can claim interest in a new field. Unpaid work is the only cheap proof that the interest is real, because nobody sustains unpaid work they do not care about.

It does not have to be impressive. It has to be real and it has to be yours.

EXAMPLE

Name one thing you have built, run, written or organized without being asked or paid, that sits on the side of the role you want rather than the job you have. A side project, a community you run, a newsletter, a teardown you wrote for nobody.

WHY THIS MATTERS: without this, part three is an assertion. With it, part three is a conclusion.

3 Part three, the sentence that only makes sense if they hire you

Close by naming the role as the thing that resolves the two facts above.

Mine was this. So I am not interested in being a hardware person or a software person. I want to be the PM who brings them together.

That sentence is not a request. It is the logical next step from two facts I have just proven. The person hearing it does not have to take a risk on me, they have to agree with an argument.

EXAMPLE

Finish this exactly: "So I am not trying to be [the obvious box you sit in] or [the box you are moving toward]. I want to be the [role] who [does the thing only someone with both would do]."

WHY THIS MATTERS: this converts a career change from something you want into something that is already true and just needs a title.

4 What the pitch deliberately leaves out

No apology. I never said "I know I don't have PM experience."

No begging. I did not ask for a referral, a job, or a favor. I explained myself and stopped talking.

No borrowed frameworks. I did not perform product management vocabulary at someone who does it for a living, which is transparent and slightly insulting.

EXAMPLE

Write your three parts, then delete every sentence that apologizes, qualifies, or asks. If what remains is shorter and stronger, it was.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the gap in your resume is the thing you are most aware of and the thing they are least interested in. Raising it makes it the subject.

5 Attach a number to yourself

Underneath all of this is a way of thinking I would give anyone.

Everyone in a hiring conversation is a salesperson, and the product is your effort. A company hires you because it believes you will return more than it costs to employ you. If you can articulate that number, you are easier to say yes to, because you have done the arithmetic for the person who has to justify you upward.

EXAMPLE

Finish this before any conversation: because of me, this team makes or saves X. Use a real figure from your current job even if it is modest. The habit is what transfers.

WHY THIS MATTERS: I could not point to PM experience, so I pointed at business impact, and that is a language the person in front of me already spoke fluently.

6 Say it out loud before you need it

I did not write this pitch at the conference. I had been explaining myself this way for a while, which is why it came out clean under pressure in front of someone who could change my life.

EXAMPLE

Say your three parts out loud ten times. Then say them to one person who does not work in your field and watch which part they stop following. Fix that part.

WHY THIS MATTERS: a pitch you have only written is a draft. A pitch you have said is a tool.

You are not going to talk your way past a missing qualification, and you should not try. What you can do is stop presenting yourself as an incomplete version of the role you want, and start presenting yourself as a complete version of something the role needs.

Three sentences. What you are deep in, what you do unpaid that proves the other half, and the role that only makes sense as both.

Write it tonight. Say it out loud tomorrow.